Yuliya Fokina

BOOKING.COM – Functional requirements

"Anywhere" date-led destination discovery

Learning exercise for the STRV Product Academy. Booking.com is the example product; system details and numbers are assumptions.

1. What we are building

"Anywhere" lets a traveller search with only **dates and guests**, see **destinations where suitable stays are available**, and book through the **existing booking flow**. The MVP has three screens: (1) "Anywhere" in the search box, (2) a list of destinations, (3) stays in one destination.

In scope

- Desktop.
- The three screens below.
- Released to all users at once.
- Analytics events (section 8).

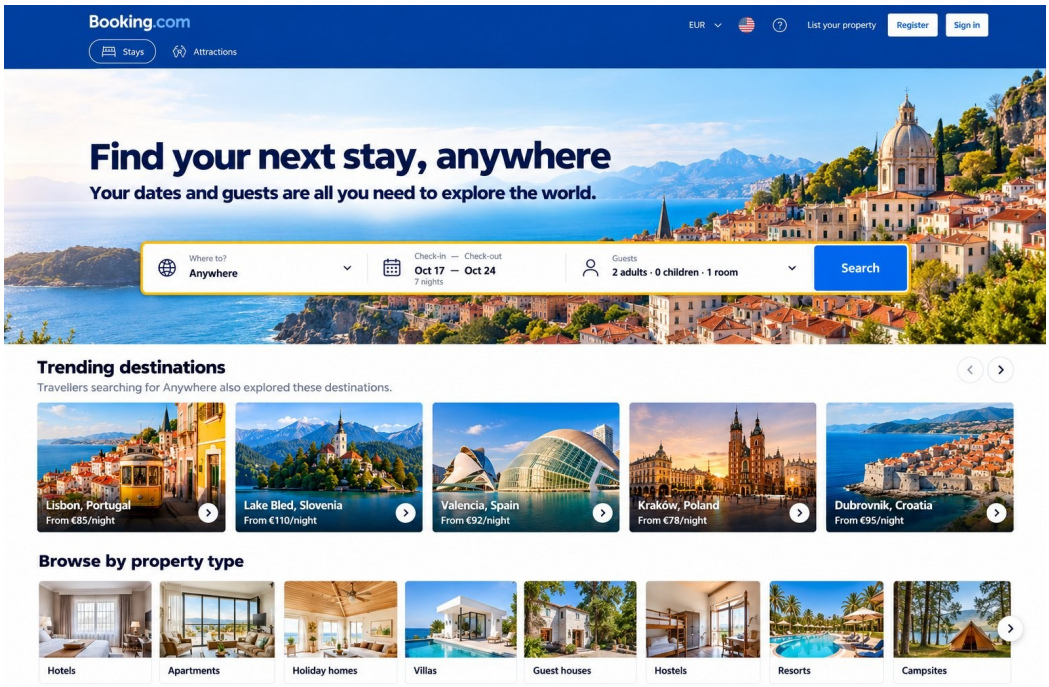
Out of scope

- Flexible dates (fixed check-in and check-out only).
- Personalised recommendations, saved lists, flights.
- Mobile web and apps.
- Changes to the property page or checkout.
- Written destination descriptions; new filters on Screen 3.

2. User stories

ID	As a traveller, I want to…	Persona
US-1	search without choosing a place, so I can see where I could go	Yuliya, Tomáš
US-2	see the price per night and the total for my stay, so I only consider places I can afford	Yuliya, Lucie
US-3	see only places and stays that fit my whole group	Lucie
US-4	get a quick, factual sense of an unfamiliar place	Tomáš, Maya
US-5	compare destinations and go back without losing my filters	All
US-6	book through the normal Booking.com flow	All

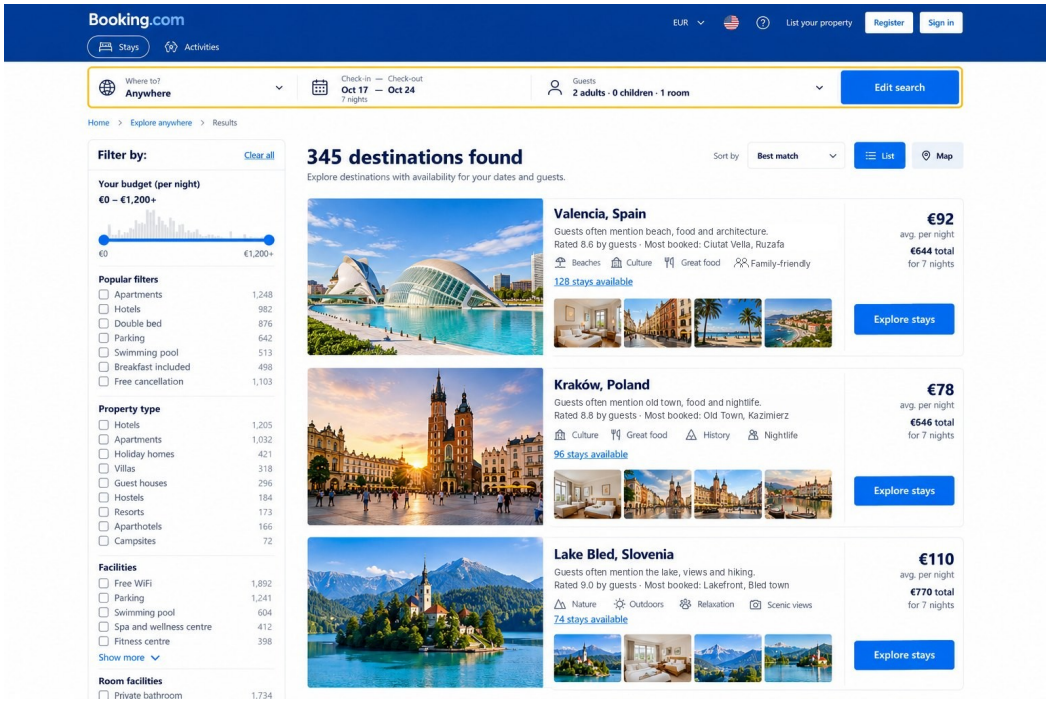
3. Screen 1: search with “Anywhere”



Screen 1: “Anywhere” in the destination field.

ID	Requirement	How we check it
FR-1.1	“Anywhere” is the first option in the destination field when the field is empty.	Click into the empty field → “Anywhere” is first.
FR-1.2	An Anywhere search needs fixed check-in and check-out dates, at least 1 adult and 1 room. Existing date and guest rules apply.	Search without dates → the date picker opens; no results are loaded.
FR-1.3	Search opens Screen 2. All inputs are in the URL.	Refresh, back or a shared link shows the same results.

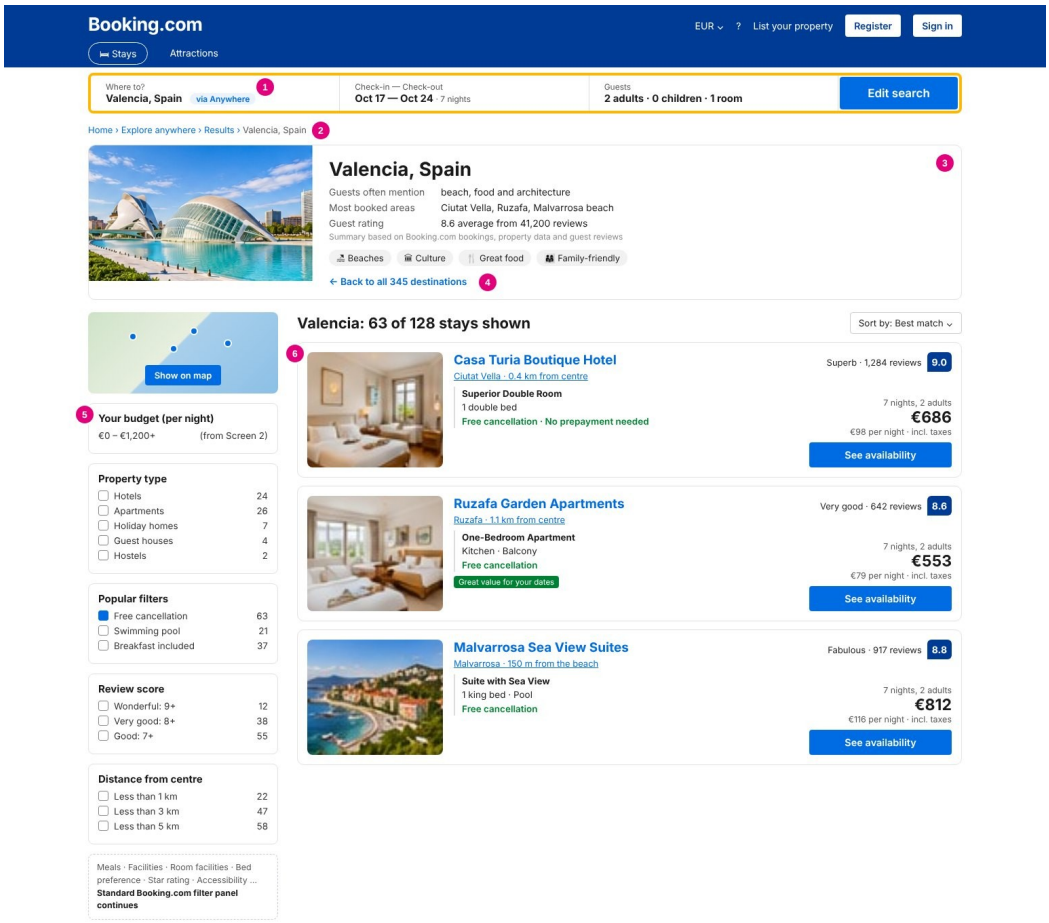
4. Screen 2: destination results



Screen 2: destinations with stays for 17–24 Oct, 2 adults.

ID	Requirement	How we check it
FR-2.1	Show every destination with **at least 1 available stay** (R-1) for the exact dates and the whole group.	2 adults + 2 children → no destination without stays for 4 people.
FR-2.2	Each card shows: photo, name and country, short data summary (R-4), up to 4 tags (R-5), “{n} stays available”, average price per night, total price for the stay (R-2), and “Explore stays”.	Total = average per night × number of nights.
FR-2.3	Sorting: Best match (default, R-3), Lowest price, Most stays.	“Lowest price” → cheapest destination first.
FR-2.4	Filters: budget per night, property type, popular filters (e.g. free cancellation, pool). The list and the URL update without a page reload.	Budget max €80 → stay counts include only stays up to €80 per night.
FR-2.5	20 destinations are shown; “Show more” loads the next 20.	After “Show more”, 40 cards; scroll position kept.
FR-2.6	*(Should)* A map view shows each destination as a pin with its price.	Clicking a pin opens the same destination as its card.
FR-2.7	Clicking a card opens Screen 3 with the same dates, guests and filters, and the tag `src=anywhere`.	Screen 3 opens with filters already applied.

5. Screen 3: explore stays



Screen 3: numbers 1–6 match the requirements below.

Screen 3 is Booking.com's **existing search results page** for one destination, with three additions: the "via Anywhere" tag (1), the destination overview (3) and the "Back to all destinations" link (4).

ID	Requirement	How we check it
FR-3.1	[1] The search bar shows the destination with a **"via Anywhere"** tag. Changing dates or guests reloads the same destination. Choosing another city opens the normal search, without the tag.	Change guests to 4 → same destination, tag still shown.
FR-3.2	[2] Breadcrumb: Home › Explore anywhere › Results › {Destination}.	"Results" opens Screen 2 with the same filters.
FR-3.3	[3] Destination overview: photo, name, a summary of up to 3 lines (guests often mention · most booked areas · guest rating, R-4), up to 4 tags (R-5) and the line "Summary based on Booking.com bookings, property data and guest reviews". A line without enough data is hidden.	Fewer than 50 reviews → "Guests often mention" and "Guest rating" are hidden.
FR-3.4	[4] "Back to all destinations" returns to Screen 2 with the same filters and scroll position.	Scroll to card 30, open, go back → still at card 30.
FR-3.5	[5] Booking.com's **standard filter panel, unchanged**. Filters chosen on Screen 2 are already applied.	Budget €150 + Apartments on Screen 2 → both pre-selected; all standard filters available.

ID	Requirement	How we check it
FR-3.6	[6] Existing property cards, only for stays that fit the whole group, with the **total price for the stay**. “See availability” opens the existing property page; `src=anywhere` is kept until booking (R-6).	A booking made this way is recorded with source “anywhere”.

6. Business rules

ID	Rule
R-1	**Available stay:** a property with at least one room offer that can be booked for the exact dates and fits all guests.
R-2	**Destination price:** for each available stay, take its cheapest offer for the whole stay (incl. taxes). **Total** = the average of these. **Per night** = total ÷ number of nights.
R-3	**Best match:** a simple score from availability (more stays), price (cheaper) and popularity, weighted 40 / 30 / 30 and adjustable. No personalisation.
R-4	**Destination summary, from existing data only:** guests often mention = top 3 topics in reviews (min. 50 reviews); most booked areas = top 3 districts by bookings; guest rating = average score (min. 50 reviews). Fixed sentence templates, no written or AI-generated text. Updated every night.
R-5	**Tags:** shown when a simple rule is met, e.g. Beaches (≥ 20% of stays near a beach), Great food (food mentioned in ≥ 15% of reviews), Family-friendly (≥ 25% of stays with family rooms). Max 4, for display only (not filters). No weather tags.
R-6	**Attribution:** `src=anywhere` is carried from Screen 2 to the booking, and the booking is saved with source “anywhere”.

7. Empty and error states

All messages appear **inside the results area, in place of the list**. There are no pop-ups. The search bar and filters stay visible, and **nothing the user selected is cleared automatically**.

Situation	What the user sees	What the user can do
Loading	3 placeholder cards.	Wait.
Filters remove all destinations	“No destinations match your filters”, with the selected filters listed, each with its own × to remove it.	Remove one filter at a time by clicking its ×.
No availability for the dates	“No destinations have availability for these dates and guests.”	“Edit dates” opens the date picker in the search bar, with the current dates filled in.
Results fail to load	“We couldn’t load destinations right now.”	“Try again” reloads with the same inputs.
Screen 3: filters remove all stays	“No stays match your filters”, with the selected filters listed, each with its own ×.	Remove one filter at a time.
Destination sold out since Screen 2	A notice at the top of Screen 3: “Stays in {Destination} just sold out for these dates.”	“Back to all destinations” opens Screen 2 with the same filters.

8. Analytics and launch

Event	When it fires
`anywhere_selected`	User chooses “Anywhere”.
`anywhere_search_submitted`	A valid Anywhere search is sent.
`destination_results_viewed`	Screen 2 is shown.
`explore_stays_clicked`	User opens a destination (Screen 3).
`property_opened`	User clicks “See availability”.
`booking_completed` / `booking_cancelled`	Existing events, now with the source “anywhere”.

Every event includes the user and the session.

Launch: released to all users at once.

Main metric: completed (not cancelled) bookings that came through “Anywhere” (source “anywhere”), per week. **Before/after check:** total bookings and search-to-booking conversion in the 4 weeks after launch vs. the 4 weeks before (and the same period last year, to account for season). **Guardrails:** conversion of normal searches, cancellation rate.

9. Open questions

- Should “Anywhere” be pre-selected in the search box, or only offered as the first option?
- Does Booking.com already group review text by topic in every language (needed for R-4 and R-5)?
- Can the availability system check ~350 destinations at once, or do we need to pre-calculate popular dates?